Guiding Principles for the Settlement of the India–China Boundary Question'. The agreement featured six key principles:

1. the two sides would seek a 'political settlement'
2. they should make 'adjustments . . . so as to arrive at a package settlement to the boundary question. The boundary settlement must be final, covering all sectors of the India–China boundary.'
3. they would give 'due consideration to each other's strategic and reasonable interests'
4. in reaching a settlement, they would rely on 'historical evidence, national sentiments, practical difficulties and reasonable concerns and sensitivities of both sides, and the actual state of the border'
5. the final boundary should be 'along well-defined and easily identifiable natural geographical features'
6. they would 'safeguard due interests of their settled populations in the border areas'

This is the most explicit statement regarding the nature of a settlement, and though it has not resolved the conflict, it did prepare the ground. The six points made clear that the two governments had given themselves plenty of room for manoeuvre in relation to their publics – virtually any criticism of a future settlement could be deflected by citing one or more of the six principles.

The 2005 agreement is notable for several things but broadly two elements stand out. The first is that there is a balance between India's preference for history, geography, and national 'sentiment' to play a part in determining the boundary lines and China's preference for politics, strategic interests, and the facts on the ground ('the actual state of the border') to play a part. India wanted a sector-by-sector approach and China wanted a deal that covered the entire border in a package, all-or-nothing stipulation, and the agreement reconciles the two positions. The second notable aspect of the agreement is that despite the use of the term 'package', it does not endorse the old swap idea. A package settlement in the 2005 accord implies that the two sides will agree to adjustments in each sector and that neither side will get everything it wants in any sector. Until they are agreed on all three sectors, they do not have an overall settlement. India and China cannot, for example, settle the relatively easy middle sector in a separate